11 Signs You're A Micromanager

1. You Can't Take Vacation

If you are the glue that holds everything together, **that's not managing**.

That's doing.

You should be able to step away for a week and only be needed in emergencies.

Worse, this dependency will keep you from getting promoted.

You can't step up if you can't step out.

2. You Only Hear "Yes"

There's zero chance you're always right.

It's impossible.

So if you're only hearing 'Yes,' you have one of two problems:

- Your **team no longer cares**
- They believe you'll overrule them

In either case, there's a good chance you've earned their apathy.

3. You're a Bottleneck

"In most organizations, **the bottleneck is at the top of the bottle**."

- How many things are waiting on you?
- How long have they been stuck?

The number of decisions that can, a) kill you and, b) can't be reversed, is exceptionally low.

Make them.

Or better yet, let someone else.

4. You Never Ask Questions

People want to feel valued, like their opinions and expertise matter.

The easiest way?

To genuinely value their opinion and expertise.

And the easiest way to show them is **ask for it**. And being **genuinely interested in their response**.

If your question-to-direction ratio isn't at least 1:1, humble yourself and fix it.

5. You See Zero Mistakes

The goal isn't zero mistakes.

Instead, it's the right mistakes that:

- Test ideas and open new doors
- Stretch and develop the team
- Encourage calculated risks

If you're getting no mistakes, aim higher and up the error rate.

6. You Can't Keep Your Stars

The best people know their value.

If you're preventing them from having the impact they're capable of and increasing their value, they'll be the first to walk.

It can be easy to write off these "**mercenaries**" for not being "**missionaries**," but don't.

Their confidence to find another hill to climb would suggest you're holding everyone back from higher peaks.

7. Your Calendar is Full of Meetings

Meetings might give the illusion that you're in control, but they're not where the work happens.

Most are virtuous procrastination.

And the more you meet, the less work there is to discuss, review and improve.

Want a surefire way to raise morale?

Have fewer meetings.

8. Your Meetings Are Lifeless

A leader I coach said he stopped doing 1:1 meetings because his people never bring meaningful topics.

Maybe they don't...

- Want to encourage your meddling.
- Feel empowered to have impact.
- Have enough real work to do.

The solution to all three? **Expect more.**

Then you'll have plenty to talk about.

9. You Discourage Skip-Level Meetings

Why don't you **want your team to talk to your boss**?

Will they tell her things are imperfect under your leadership? Of course.

Will they feel more valued and empowered because they know her?

Definitely.

Plus, she'll use their insights to make connections and offer you coaching she would have otherwise missed.

10. You Can't Name Your Employee's Kids

Challenging directly must be paired with caring personally (h/t Radical Candor).

Otherwise, people will feel like objects, not assets.

If you can't name the people closest to your employees or how they spend their weekends, you might be long the work and short the worker.

Try and balance your empathy budget.

11. You're On The Edge of Burnout

You're exhausted, and we've already noted you can't take a break without creating more work for yourself.

And leaders burnout for the same reasons they're employees do:

- You're not growing
- You're not having an impact
- You're not able to get it all done

The root cause is almost always because you're finding comfort doing your team's job **instead of stepping up to do yours.**

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